

How You Speak and Write: Ocean Vuong Teaches the Art of Writing (NYU Professor)

Various speakers

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Chapter 1

Ocean Vuong Teaches the Art of Writing

This chapter follows a conversation between Ocean Vuong and the host in the LazyLearn writing and speaking collection, with curation by LazyingArt LLC. The lecture begins by converting admiration into method: awe, freshness, enchantment, wonder, all become a practical craft question. How do we make language see again? No validated board or slide mathematics survives for this lecture, so the displayed formulas below are transcript-backed condensations of spoken structure rather than visual transcriptions. They are useful here because the lecture itself repeatedly thinks in contrasts, transfers, thresholds, and causal chains.

1.1 Metaphor, Observation, and the First Break from Mimesis

The host opens by naming a quality in Vuong's work before naming a method. There is wonder in the writing, but there is also wonder in the way of seeing, and the host asks whether such seeing can be cultivated like a muscle. Vuong's first answer is immediate and technical: metaphor is the place where this question becomes teachable. If students ask how to write a good metaphor, the first answer is not brilliance, and it is not ornament. It is observation. One looks at the world for a long time. The rest, he says, is arrangement and syntax.

Definition 1.1. Let the tenor be the thing under description and the vehicle be the thing that carries the description elsewhere. Then Vuong's opening schema for metaphor is

$$(\text{tenor, vehicle}) \implies \text{new correspondence} \implies \text{re-seeing.} \quad (1.1)$$

A metaphor succeeds when the correspondence forces the reader to perceive the tenor again rather than merely recognize it.

This is why the lecture immediately reaches for the Aristotelian split between two sentence-functions:

$$\text{mimesis : known scene} \mapsto \text{recognizable description,} \quad (1.2)$$

$$\text{poiesis : known scene} \mapsto \text{estranged process.} \quad (1.3)$$

The mimetic sentence brings us back to what we already know how to name. The poetic sentence interrupts that automatic naming. In that spirit Vuong's opening rule can be written as

$$\text{metaphor} \neq \text{ornament}, \quad \text{metaphor} = \text{observation} + \text{arrangement/syntax.} \quad (1.4)$$

The lecture's first worked example is Isaac Babel's sunset in *Red Cavalry*. Vuong contrasts a newspaper-style line, "a red evening sunset along the hills," with Babel's low red sun rolling across the hills "as if beheaded." The point is not merely that Babel is vivid. The point is that the historical situation is carried inside the sentence. We do not need external commentary telling us that Babel writes out of war. The image does that work itself. It also changes the felt motion of the scene.

Worked Example: Babel's Sunset.

$$\text{sunset} + \text{beheading image} \implies \text{war context embedded in perception}, \quad (1.5)$$

$$\text{embedded violence} \implies \text{altered rate of the sunset}. \quad (1.6)$$

1. We begin with a fully recognizable scene: a sunset over hills.
2. We add an image that does not merely decorate the sunset but carries violence into it.
3. That added image embeds historical consciousness inside the perception itself.
4. The sunset now seems to roll, fall, and lose its head; the second clause changes the speed of the scene.
5. The line therefore does more than describe. It reorganizes the reader's seeing.

Vuong gives this ambition a deliberately severe slogan:

$$\text{competent sentence} \neq \text{sentence the species has never had yet}. \quad (1.7)$$

The left-hand side is not useless. We still need scaffolding sentences. But the lecture begins by insisting that the writer's deeper task is not merely to produce competent recognition. It is to make possible a new perceptual event.

1.1.1 Question & Answer

How do we write a metaphor that does more than mimic the world?

We do not begin by chasing cleverness. We begin by looking until the object's ready-made label becomes inadequate. Then we search for a vehicle that changes the object's pressure, pace, or emotional weather. The sequence is practical:

1. Identify the tenor and keep looking until it stops feeling generic.
2. Choose a vehicle from sustained observation rather than from stock resemblance.
3. Build a correspondence that alters the scene rather than merely embellishing it.
4. Keep the line only if the reader is made to see, not merely to recognize.

This is why strong metaphor may take years to arrive. The hard part is not syntax alone. The hard part is earning the right correspondence.

1.2 Workshop as Recognition, Not Correction

Once the lecture has shown what a live sentence can do, the host narrows the lens. If writing can be timid or alive, how do we teach writers to notice the difference in their own work? Vuong's answer

is to replace workshop-as-correction with workshop-as-recognition. The shift is subtle but decisive. A workshop does not automatically help simply because it produces more comments, more drafts, or more process.

The lecture compresses the contrast like this:

$$\text{pattern recognition} \implies \text{self-recognition} \implies \text{more intelligent revision}, \quad (1.8)$$

$$\text{dogmatic correction} \implies \text{homogenization or destruction of the work}. \quad (1.9)$$

This matters because the broader culture tempts us to think like a factory. Feed the work into a machine, apply more procedure, and it should become better. Vuong rejects that fantasy. Some workshops destroy the work. Some drafts move beyond the pinnacle of the work. What looks like productivity can become rubble.

The lecture's clearest formal definition appears here:

$$\text{sentence} = \text{consciousness filtered through syntax}. \quad (1.10)$$

If that is right, then workshop must begin by asking what kind of consciousness the draft is already revealing. Which images recur? Which verbs fall across line breaks? Where does a paragraph switch tense? Which prepositions keep launching the line forward? Vuong's classroom examples are deliberately concrete because the point is not "theme" in the abstract. The point is to see the formal habits by which a mind is already moving.

This is also why the lecture returns to the dangers of overproduction. A poet who writes a poem every day for a year may not end up with more usable work. They may end up with a field of debris that is harder to salvage than a fresh beginning. Recognition, by contrast, asks a simpler question: what is already happening here? Once that question becomes serious, revision stops being the application of dogma and becomes the clarification of tendency.

The Japanese botanist anecdote turns this into a method. Asked how he found so many medicinal plants, the botanist says that he did not search for what looked like known medicine. He simply searched for what was new to him and hoped it might be medicine. Sometimes it was not. Sometimes it was poison. But novelty-seeking, not resemblance to an approved model, is what enlarged the field. Vuong clearly offers this as a model for the writing classroom.

1.2.1 Question & Answer

Why can more feedback and more drafting make a piece worse instead of better?

Because more process is not the same as better recognition. Revision fails when it is governed by inherited rules that the work itself has not earned. Vuong's alternative is procedural but not mechanical:

1. Read for patterns before proposing repair.
2. Name recurring formal tendencies in diction, tense, syntax, image, and line-movement.
3. Ask where the piece becomes unexpectedly alive.
4. Revise toward those discoveries rather than toward generic correctness.

In this model, workshop does not manufacture the poem. It helps the writer arrive sooner at what the poem was already trying to become.

1.3 How the Sentence Was Tamed

After the interruption, the lecture does not return by recap. It returns by tension. The host asks about novelty, surprise, freshness, and whether the pursuit of quality may itself become restrictive. Vuong answers by widening the frame. The modern sentence, he argues, is not a timeless standard of good writing. It is a historical product.

That larger history begins with a prior question: what do we even mean by literature? Vuong insists that the category itself is late. Before the modern department and its institutional sorting, the boundaries between poem, story, letter, speech, and practical writing were far looser. Even the novel was not always treated as a serious literary instrument. Its later moral elevation, especially in the American context after the Civil War, coincided with another development: the standardization of journalism.

The lecture's historical contrast can be written schematically:

$$\text{oratorical / Victorian sentence} \implies \text{delay} + \text{subordination} + \text{buildup}, \quad (1.11)$$

$$\text{newspaper sentence} \implies \text{brevity} + \text{clarity} + \text{efficiency} + \text{standardization}. \quad (1.12)$$

The older sentence belongs to sermon, speech, public argument, and a culture in which rhythm and suspension keep attention alive. The newer sentence belongs to information delivery. It must be reliable, clear, fast, and brief enough to coexist with circulation and advertising.

This is why Churchill's anaphora appears in the lecture not as a random digression but as a live memory of the older sentence. "We shall fight..." delays the payoff while building public force. Vuong then returns, cautiously but clearly, to the stable claim we can preserve from a partially corrupted stretch of transcript: twentieth-century prose absorbed the newspaper model, and writers such as Hemingway, Crane, London, and Orwell came to stand for the clipped, efficient sentence that our culture now often calls simply "good writing."

The argument becomes more pointed when the host offers the image of right angles. Much contemporary prose, he says, feels ruler-straight, angular, coarse, and over-refined. Vuong seizes the analogy:

$$\text{industrial right angle} \implies \text{cultural preference for standardized form}. \quad (1.13)$$

This is not literal geometry. It is a way of describing the historical drift by which industrial modernity teaches us to value clean edges, repeatability, and mass-producible surfaces. Prose acquires the same aspiration. The sentence becomes "invisible," efficient, and suspicious of authorial pressure.

From there the lecture moves naturally into its contemporary examples. Microsoft Word covers Shakespeare with correction marks. AI appears not as a sudden betrayal of human language but as the continuation of a much older project of homogenization. Long before automated prose, we had already been training the sentence toward sameness.

1.3.1 Question & Answer

Why does contemporary prose so often sound standardized even when we praise innovation?

Because our institutions praise innovation retrospectively and suppress it procedurally. We teach the daring masters and then ask the living student to sound less conspicuous, less idiosyncratic, less unlike existing product. Editing, review culture, software, and market fear all reward recognizability. The result is not the death of prose, but the narrowing of what prose is permitted to sound like.

1.4 Estrangement, Thresholds, and Learning to See Again

Once that narrowing has been diagnosed, the host names disenchantment directly. Vuong answers with the key counter-principle of the middle lecture: estrangement. Here Viktor Shklovsky becomes central. The boldest claim is that there is no such thing as cliché in the object itself. Cliché lives in exhausted treatment. If we keep banning roses, grandmothers, kitchens, mountains, or flowers as "already used," we eventually exile the world from literature.

The basic structure is:

$$\text{familiar object} + \text{unexpected placement} \implies \text{fresh perception.} \quad (1.14)$$

Hence the lecture's sharpest illustration:

$$\text{rose in bridesmaid's hair} \neq \text{rose in Mike Tyson's ear.} \quad (1.15)$$

The rose is unchanged. The treatment is changed. So the lesson is not "never write the rose." The lesson is "reconsider the rose."

Shklovsky's quotation from Tolstoy deepens the point. Tolstoy cannot remember whether he has dusted the sofa, because the act was routine and unconscious. If life is lived only in routine, it passes almost as if it had never been lived. Literature matters here because it interrupts routine. It restores the difference between seeing and merely recognizing.

The host's analogies are especially important in this portion of the lecture because they keep the abstraction concrete. Bierstadt makes a mountain visible again. Monet's lilies and Van Gogh's flowers show not just objecthood but energy. The host then reaches for video editing and early photography: when we zoom into the frames, what looked like a single smooth act is revealed as multiple distinct moments. That is exactly what Vuong wants from perception. Writing must slow the world enough for us to encounter its intermediate states.

This returns the lecture to Aristotle:

$$\text{bud} \rightsquigarrow \text{rose}, \quad \text{poiesis} = \text{threshold region between named states.} \quad (1.16)$$

The rose is a named thing. The bud is a named thing. But there are innumerable phases between them. Those phases are not unreal simply because they are hard to name. On the contrary, Vuong says, wonder lives there. Heidegger's language of threshold helps because it asks a question that ordinary naming tries to skip: where, exactly, does the rose become the rose?

This is a crucial improvement over a merely textbook account of poiesis. Vuong is not invoking Aristotle as historical decoration. He is using Aristotle to mark the exact place where mimetic naming gives out and living process begins.

1.4.1 Question & Answer

Is a subject cliché in itself, or only when we fail to estrange it?

In this lecture, the subject is not guilty. The treatment is guilty. A subject becomes dead only when we approach it through stale recognition. The practical rule is therefore:

1. Do not ban the familiar object.

2. Refuse the first available treatment of that object.
3. Reposition it, re-time it, or rename it.
4. Stay with it until recognition opens back into seeing.

Estrangement is not the rejection of the world. It is the recovery of the world from habit.

1.5 Syntax, Haunting, and the Pattern Logic of Reading

Once perception has been reopened, the lecture shifts to a new puzzle. It is no longer enough to ask how we see. We have to ask how that seeing survives in the reader. Vuong states the problem bluntly: he is less interested in how to hook a reader than in how to stay with one. The host keeps translating the point into readerly terms, and the result is one of the lecture's clearest formulations.

Vuong's ratio is rough, but useful:

$$80\% \text{ looking and thinking,} \quad 20\% \text{ syntax.} \quad (1.17)$$

He immediately corrects the listener's likely misunderstanding. The final twenty percent is "everything," because syntax is the downloading mechanism. The lecture's working model is therefore

$$\text{perception} + \text{syntactic shaping} \implies \text{readerly stain} / \text{haunting.} \quad (1.18)$$

The Siken example shows how this works in practice. The stars become "little boats rowed out too far." The tenor is familiar enough:

$$\text{tenor} = \text{stars,} \quad (1.19)$$

$$\text{vehicle} = \text{boats rowed out too far.} \quad (1.20)$$

But the correspondence changes the whole symbolic regime. Stars, ordinarily grand and mythic, become intimate, lonely, late, vulnerable. The line does not merely offer a fresh comparison. It changes the emotional scale of the night sky.

Ben Lerner then supplies a harsher pedagogical version of the same demand. The student's line is "decent"; Google reveals that hundreds of thousands have already written it. The blow is memorable because it sharpens the lecture's opening criterion. Competence is not enough if the line leaves perception where it found it.

From here the lecture turns naturally to haunting. Browning's Meeting at Night stays in Vuong precisely because it cannot be reduced to paraphrase. The same is true of the park-bench scene in Good Will Hunting. A flat sentence about love and experience could have delivered the concept. But the scene becomes powerful when it passes into vulnerable, image-rich syntax. The host's role in this stretch is crucial: he keeps restating what has happened in plainer language. Ten seconds earlier, the scene was a recognition. Now it is a way of seeing.

The argument then broadens from sentence to art in general:

$$\text{pattern} \implies \text{either satisfy expectation or deny expectation.} \quad (1.21)$$

Because a sentence is a linear technology, it unfolds through time. So does music. So does film editing. So does a DJ set. So does a skate video. Once sequence exists, expectation exists. And once expectation exists, the maker gains two fundamental resources:

$$\text{satisfy/deny expectation} \implies \text{delight} + \text{surprise} + \text{estrangement.} \quad (1.22)$$

Pattern Rule.

1. A linear art creates expectation by unfolding in time.
2. The maker may satisfy that expectation or hold it off.
3. Delay intensifies attention because the audience senses a withheld completion.
4. The release, or the refusal of release, creates delight and surprise.
5. At that point we are no longer merely following content. We are feeling the intelligence of pattern itself.

This is why Vuong can move so easily among literature, street-ball deception, skate parts, and DJ timing. The analogy is not ornamental. It is structural.

1.5.1 Question & Answer

How does a sentence stay with a reader rather than merely hook one?

A hook captures the eye for a moment. Haunting remains after the moment. In Vuong's account, a sentence stays when the syntactic shape is adequate to the pressure of perception. The line must not merely communicate a concept. It must enter the reader with rhythm, delay, and pressure. That is why abstraction becomes memorable only when it is given a body.

1.6 Poetry and Nature Writing as Laboratories of Language

From readerly after-effect the lecture broadens again, now into artistic formation. The question becomes: where can a sentence still take risks? Vuong's answer is that poetry and nature writing preserve freedoms that most contemporary prose has partially surrendered.

The first claim is direct:

$$\text{assignment removed} \implies \text{language becomes available for experiment.} \quad (1.23)$$

The second follows from it:

$$\text{poetry, nature writing} \implies \text{highest local freedom for the sentence.} \quad (1.24)$$

Poetry is an obvious laboratory because one need not maintain plot, explanatory clarity, or character-management at every instant. Nature writing becomes a parallel laboratory for a subtler reason: pure mimesis collapses there. We have already seen the meadow. We already know what mud looks like. Why should we read a sentence that only duplicates available sight?

The J.A. Baker passage answers that question by demonstration. Baker begins with plain weather and marsh description, then enters a proliferating mud-syntax that no longer merely names material. Mud becomes pressure, texture, danger, condition, psychic field. By the end, Baker's interiority has leached into the object:

$$\text{mud description} + \text{released interiority} \implies \text{mimesis broken.} \quad (1.25)$$

This is exactly the movement Vuong wants the notes to preserve. Baker is not abandoning the world. He is allowing subjective force to change what the world can look like on the page.

The host contributes another essential term here: fun. That word matters because otherwise the lecture could become all theory and denunciation. The delight of a crayon box with many blues becomes a model of artistic perception. When we multiply shades, textures, and uses, we do not merely classify more finely. We reopen wonder. That is why the lecture can move, without strain, from Baker's mud to childlike attention.

The Shklovsky-Tolstoy material returns at this point in a slightly different register. Tolstoy does not say "birch"; he says, in effect, a large curly-headed tree with a white luminous trunk. The point is not descriptive excess. The point is to make us believe the child again. Definition can become the enemy of imagination when it closes the object too early.

That is also why Eduardo C. Corral's moss simile is so important in the late lecture. The transcript is unstable just before the example, but the technical claim is secure. The comparison works not image-to-image, but behavior-to-behavior:

$$\text{applause} \not\sim \text{moss by image}, \quad \text{applause} \sim \text{moss by behavior}, \quad (1.26)$$

$$\text{behavioral correspondence} \implies \text{apparent acceleration of moss growth}. \quad (1.27)$$

Worked Example: Moss and Applause.

1. We do not ask what moss resembles statically.
2. We ask how moss behaves, or how we might newly perceive its behavior.
3. "Applause" lends quickened, nebulous, collective motion to moss.
4. The transferred behavior makes the moss seem to move before our eyes.
5. The simile therefore changes the target's temporal experience rather than merely decorating it.

The anecdote that Corral spent nine years on a short book matters because it closes a loop that began with Babel. Strong metaphor is not instant cleverness. It is the result of prolonged looking.

1.6.1 Question & Answer

Why do poetry and nature writing preserve freedom for the sentence better than most contemporary prose?

Because both forms loosen the immediate pressure of assignment. Poetry can focus on language itself. Nature writing cannot survive as mere report, since the visible object is already known. Both therefore force the sentence toward poesis, estrangement, and play. The laboratory is simply the space in which the writer is permitted to discover more than one use for the world.

1.7 Publishing Time, Reader Time, and the Ethics of Daringness

The late lecture now shifts from local craft to larger systems. House style, pedagogical cynicism, Hollywood conservatism, the "reader in the Midwest," and Lotman's two-time model all become parts of one question: why does the system celebrate originality in principle while disciplining it into sameness in practice?

Vuong has already shown how the sentence becomes standardized. He now shows how institutions actively preserve that standardization. The New Yorker example matters because it is not simple denunciation. House style teaches clarity. It also produces brand-recognition. A writer may publish there and discover that the piece is still theirs in idea, but no longer wholly theirs in cadence. The point is not that house style is evil. The point is that clarity, efficacy, and brand-expectation are never neutral.

The anecdote about the "reader in the Midwest" sharpens that cynicism. An editor asks whether such a reader can handle baroque prose. Vuong hears in the question not democratic care but condescension. The ordinary reader, he insists, has a nervous system, a memory, and a reading life. That anecdote prepares the transition to Uri Lotman:

$$\text{reading} = (\text{synchronic line}, \text{diachronic line}). \quad (1.28)$$

A synchronic reading occurs inside the season, the publicity cycle, the market year, the institutional moment. A diachronic reading occurs against the longer accumulation of reading through time.

This produces the lecture's strongest institutional contrast:

$$\text{system judges synchronically}, \quad \text{reader judges diachronically}. \quad (1.29)$$

Publishing works in seasons. Review culture works in seasons. Critics often work in seasons. Readers do not. A reader may have been reading Shakespeare, Melville, Baldwin, Annie Dillard, or Chaucer long before today's prize-listed novel arrives. So a book standardized for synchronic success may meet a very different test when it falls into diachronic hands.

The host's Rotten Tomatoes analogy is perfect here because it translates Lotman's theory into a familiar cultural split. Critics are embedded in a more institutional present. Audiences arrive with a less regulated accumulation of comparison. The lecture's point is not that audiences are pure and critics corrupt. The point is that the two are operating on different clocks.

Vuong then returns from publication-time to language-time. Definition can constrict, but it can also expand. Good dictionaries and etymologies reopen words instead of closing them. The example of passion is decisive: what modern usage hears as enthusiasm or intensity carries an older history of suffering. Once we recover that history, the word is altered. This is the bridge to Wittgenstein:

$$\text{meaning of a word} = \text{its use}. \quad (1.30)$$

Use changes definition. The dictionary catches up to us. That lesson is especially important for students because intimidation by official rule is one more path back into standardization.

From here the lecture widens once more, from lexicon to culture:

$$\text{innovation on the margins} \implies \text{capture by the center} \implies \text{homogenized product}. \quad (1.31)$$

The margin is mobile. The center captures. Lotman's concentric model of culture explains why innovation so often begins outside the recognized center and then returns as flattened commodity. The same holds for words, styles, scenes, and forms.

The host then asks the most practical late question of all: what should a writer actually do? Vuong's answer is not another technical rule. It is an ethic: daringness and disobedience. Daringness is the willingness to wager and risk failure. Disobedience is the refusal to step back into line merely because line-keeping brings praise. The skateboarding analogy matters because it gives daringness

a felt form. One throws oneself toward a trick without certainty of landing. Failure is not an accidental byproduct. It is part of the practice itself.

The lecture ends by pushing past craft into philosophical risk. Language has made Vuong's life. It has given him livelihood, access, and enlargement of perception. Yet the same language can be captured by tyranny. Newspapers and radio are among the first targets of authoritarian control. The closing paradox must therefore remain intact:

$$\text{language} \implies \text{power} + \text{livelihood} + \text{enlargement of perception}, \quad (1.32)$$

$$\text{language} \implies \text{capture} + \text{tyranny} + \text{homogenization}. \quad (1.33)$$

Thomas Thistlewood's library, the cultivated brutality of Nazi officers, and the other historical examples keep the lecture from becoming sentimental. At the same time, Harriet Beecher Stowe remains on the other side of the ledger. Literature sometimes does alter history. Vuong insists on both truths at once.

1.7.1 Question & Answer

Why does the culture ask for originality and then reward conformity, and what is a writer supposed to do about it?

Because institutions need recognizable product. Standardization is easier to edit, brand, circulate, and praise. The writer's answer, in this lecture, is not purity but practice:

1. protect the original matrix of surprise,
2. read diachronically rather than only seasonally,
3. trust living use more than official intimidation,
4. cultivate daringness and disobedience together,
5. accept that language is powerful without pretending it is innocent.

The lecture offers no guarantee that this path will be rewarded. It offers only the claim that anything less will make the sentence too timid to live.

1.8 Summary

The lecture unfolds by steady widening. A question about metaphor becomes a question about workshop. A question about workshop becomes a question about the history of the sentence. That history opens onto estrangement, threshold, syntax, pattern, poetry, nature writing, publication-time, reader-time, and finally the moral ambiguity of language itself. At each step the argument contracts again into a local example: Babel's sunset, the botanist's method, the rose displaced, Siken's stars, Baker's mud, Corral's moss, the reader in the Midwest.

What remains at the end is not a doctrine of stylistic maximalism. It is a more exact standard of attention. We are asked to look longer, to distrust mere recognizability, to hear the sentence as a carrier of consciousness, and to remember that formal daring is both an artistic and an ethical wager. The lecture ends where it ought to end: not in resolution, but in heightened seriousness about what language can do, and what it cannot promise.